When investigations remained permanently open without chargesheets, individual officers exercised enormous informal power over accused persons, with allegations that payments were sought in exchange for relief from summons. When Navin set out to break this slothful pattern, he moved first through the institutional machinery he had at hand: the Quarterly Conference of Zonal Officers, the forums at which zonal heads review performance with national leadership. At these conferences—held across FY25 and FY26—a singular directive was hammered home across field formations: treat the filing of a PC as the true measure of investigative completion. Mature cases were to be identified, evidence consolidated and chargesheets filed without avoidable delay.

THE PC PUSH

Navin set a target of 500 PCs for FY26. It was a break from the past, especially when he made it clear that this was an accountability benchmark, with field formations directed to review pending Enforcement Case Information Reports (ECIRs) systematically and identify matters amenable to prosecution. "The need for this enhanced target is to proactively conclude long-pending investigations and to systematically reduce the lifecycle of new investigations to a reasonable timeframe of one to two years, except in exceptionally complex cases," says a senior officer who attended the conference. The results were striking. While the directorate closed 85 cases in FY24 and 198 in FY25, the figure jumped to 685 in FY26—more than an eight-fold increase in two years. Statistical closures—a category specifically introduced to acknowledge cases where the final PC has been filed and only the trial phase remains—jumped from 93 to 429 in a single year.

So, how did Navin and his team bring about such a dramatic turnaround in prosecution? The officer says it was not easy to meet the stiff targets, especially given that the ED's manpower has remained 2,000 since 2011, even as investigations have increased manifold in both number and complexity. So, the directorate began leveraging data analysis software, used Open Source Intelligence (OSINT) techniques, advanced cyber forensic tools, and integrated access to domestic and international intelligence platforms, including the National Intelligence Grid (NATGRID), the financial intelligence unit (FINnet 2.0) and the Inter-operable Criminal Justice System (ICJS). These enabled ED officers to triangulate financial intelligence from multiple databases simultaneously, trace cryptocurrency flows through blockchain analytics, and access corporate and property records in real time. Dedicated capacity-building sessions were conducted at the 33rd Quarterly Conference of Zonal Officers to standardise these tools across all offices.

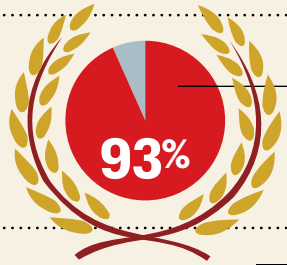
Then, to speed up the process of chargesheets, the ED made a deliberate pivot from what the directorate's own internal documents describe as a 'person/summon-centric approach' to a 'technology-centric approach' to investigation. For years, critics argued that the ED's primary instrument was the compulsory appearance under Section 50 of the PMLA—a lever that placed enormous informal power in the hands of investigating officers. Filing the chargesheet moves the case from the investigator's desk to the court's docket, thereby removing the weapon of discretion in the hands of ED investigators. Meanwhile, to remove other means of corruption within the department, as well as by the unscrupulous elements, the ED brought in measures such as QR code-based verification of summons and structured approval mechanisms, wherein senior officers approve the issuance of summons based on need

NAVIN SET A TARGET OF 500 PCs FOR FY26, MAKING IT CLEAR THAT THIS WAS AN ACCOUNTABILITY BENCHMARK

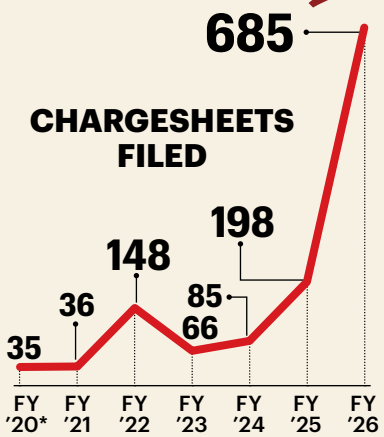
GAINING MOMENTUM

The ED maintains a strong conviction record as enforcement expands and recoveries continue to grow

60
No. of cases disposed as on Mar. 31



56
No. of cases in which convictions secured



*Aug. 1, 2019 to Mar. 31, 2020

RESTITUTION

₹63,213 cr.
Cumulative amount, all time
Returned to banks, depositors, homebuyers and investors as on Mar. 31

